the regime's hands. A collaborative effort by the ethnic groups could be beneficial in trying to finalize a lasting settlement.

At times, the ceasefire process seemed to be leading to progress, but most of the time these were short-lived for several reasons. A break in the fighting with the military was usually temporary. A military presence in most ethnic regions continued, which in many cases sparked fighting. Second, the exploitation of natural resources caused increased tension in many of the ethnic areas. The question of who would benefit from the resource extraction was at the root of the escalating tension. This point underlines the core problem of the lack of economic development in most ethnic communities. The tension between the state and ethnic regions has also caused human rights violations to be a persistent problem.

THE KACHIN CASE STUDY

During the early 1960s, the Kachin Independence Organization (KIO) was formed. The masses within the Kachin community tended to push for independence, while the leadership had the more realistic goal of autonomy within a federal system. During the next several decades, alliances were formed and broken between the numerous ethnic groups that had grievances with the military junta. Ceasefires with the regime were commonplace but never long lasting.

Unquestionably, the most serious ethnic problem is the ongoing dispute in the Kachin area. This problem is centered in the Kachin state as well as the northern region of the Shan state. The KIO is the most unified and organized resistance group currently opposing the regime in Myanmar. Earlier ceasefires have failed to lead to any long-term sustainable peace in the region.

During the early 1990s, war weariness had set in, leading to reconciliation with the government. The KIO leadership believed that it was in the best interest of the Kachin people to be included in the national political process. After a series of negotiations throughout the early 1990s, a final ceasefire agreement was signed in February 1994. The agreement included the establishment of a liaison office to ensure open communications; guarantees for peace between the former warring factions; and, finally, emphasis on efforts toward economic development. The KIO